

A counterexample to Erdős Problem 1075

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Abstract

Erdős asked whether, for every fixed $r \geq 3$, there is a constant $c_r > r^{-r}$ such that, for every $\varepsilon > 0$, every sufficiently large r -uniform hypergraph on N vertices with at least $(1 + \varepsilon)(N/r)^r$ edges contains a subgraph on $m \rightarrow \infty$ vertices with at least $c_r m^r$ edges. We give counterexamples for every $r \geq 5$. The base construction is a sequence of explicit 5-uniform hypergraphs G_n whose unnormalized Lagrangians satisfy

$$5^{-5} \left(1 + \frac{1}{4(3n)^3} \right) \leq \lambda(G_n) \leq 5^{-5} + \frac{1}{4!n}.$$

Blow-ups give the counterexample for $r = 5$, and adjoining common vertices to every edge lifts it to all larger uniformities. Thus Problem 1075, as a statement for all $r \geq 3$, has a negative answer. The endpoint question remains open for $3 \leq r \leq 4$, including the case $2/9$ for 3-graphs.

1 Introduction

All hypergraphs in this paper are finite and simple. For a hypergraph H , write $v(H) = |V(H)|$, $e(H) = |E(H)|$, and let $H[S]$ denote the subgraph induced by $S \subseteq V(H)$.

Erdős proved that, for every fixed $r \geq 2$ and $\varepsilon > 0$, an r -uniform hypergraph on N vertices with at least εN^r edges contains a complete r -partite r -uniform hypergraph with equal part sizes tending to infinity with N [1]. In particular, it contains a subgraph on $m \rightarrow \infty$ vertices with $(m/r)^r$ edges. Erdős subsequently conjectured that, for each fixed $r \geq 3$, there is a constant $c_r > r^{-r}$ such that, for every $\varepsilon > 0$ and all sufficiently large N , the assumption

$$e(H) \geq (1 + \varepsilon)(N/r)^r$$

forces a subgraph on $m = m(N) \rightarrow \infty$ vertices with at least $c_r m^r$ edges [3, p. 80]. This is Problem 1075 in Bloom's collection [13].

With the usual density $d(H) = e(H)/\binom{v(H)}{r}$, the threshold $(N/r)^r$ corresponds asymptotically to $\alpha_r = r!/r^r$. Erdős proved that every number in $[0, \alpha_r)$ is a jump for r -graphs [2]. Thus Problem 1075 is the endpoint question at α_r . Frankl and Rödl disproved the earlier jumping constant conjecture by constructing non-jumps for every $r \geq 3$ [4]. Frankl, Peng, Rödl and Talbot later showed that $(5/2)r!/r^r$ is a non-jump for every $r \geq 3$ [5], and Peng proved the lifting theorem that carries a non-jump of the form $cr!/r^r$ to all larger uniformities [6]. Yan and Peng proved that $12/25$ is a non-jump for 3-graphs, yielding $(54/25)r!/r^r$ for every $r \geq 3$ by lifting [7].

Shaw recently proved that $2r!/r^r$ is a non-jump for every $r \geq 4$, and that for $r \geq 4$ no smaller non-jump can be obtained from his finite-pattern formulation of the Frankl–Rödl method [8, Theorems 4.2 and 4.3]. Liu and Mubayi subsequently proved that $4/9$ is a non-jump for 3-graphs by a construction outside that finite-pattern framework [9]. The endpoint $2/9$ for 3-graphs remains

open; Baber and Talbot proved, using flag algebras, the first jump intervals immediately above it [10]. The result below shows that the endpoint is a non-jump for every $r \geq 5$; the cases $3 \leq r \leq 4$ remain open.

The construction below is not an instance of Shaw's finite-pattern criterion. Its distinguished links between the two vertex families follow the matching $A_i B_i$ and the shifted matching $B_i A_{i+1}$ around a cycle, and the proof controls the full Lagrangian of a growing sequence G_n . Hence Shaw's Theorem 4.3 does not apply.

Theorem 1. *For every $\gamma > 5^{-5}$, there is an $\varepsilon > 0$ and there are arbitrarily large 5-uniform hypergraphs H such that*

$$e(H) \geq (1 + \varepsilon)(v(H)/5)^5, \quad e(H[S]) < \gamma|S|^5 \quad \text{for every nonempty } S \subseteq V(H).$$

The conclusion is stronger than the formulation of Problem 1075, since the bound holds for every nonempty vertex subset. Taking $5^{-5} < \gamma < c_5$ in Theorem 1 rules out any $c_5 > 5^{-5}$. In the usual density normalization, it also implies that $5!/5^5$ is a non-jump. The proof uses explicit finite hypergraphs whose Lagrangians approach 5^{-5} from above. We use the standard unnormalized Lagrangian [11, 12],

$$P_H(x) = \sum_{e \in E(H)} \prod_{v \in e} x_v, \quad \lambda(H) = \max_{\substack{x_v \geq 0 \\ \sum_v x_v = 1}} P_H(x), \quad (1.1)$$

without the factor $r!$.

Proposition 2. *For every integer $n \geq 2$, the 5-uniform hypergraph G_n defined in Section 2 has $2n + 7$ vertices and satisfies*

$$5^{-5} \left(1 + \frac{1}{4(3n)^3}\right) \leq \lambda(G_n) \leq 5^{-5} + \frac{1}{4!n}. \quad (1.2)$$

The mechanism is visible at the level of the cubic forms. After normalizing the bottom mass, the balanced weighting on the closed cycle has

$$b_i + c = B - b_i + D = a_{i+1} + c = A - a_{i+1} + D = \frac{1}{3},$$

so both cubic forms attain $1/27$ even with $D > 0$, while the additional edge $\{U, V\} \cup \mathcal{D}$ contributes a gain of order D^3 . Deleting one pair A_k, B_k opens the cycle; the terminal mismatch forces a loss of order D^3 with a coefficient large enough to absorb that gain. Consequently every open path T_L has Lagrangian exactly 5^{-5} , whereas the closed cycle has Lagrangian slightly above 5^{-5} .

2 The cyclic construction

Fix $n \geq 2$. Take pairwise distinct vertices

$$A_i, B_i \quad (i \in \mathbb{Z}/n\mathbb{Z}), \quad C, U, V, \quad W_1, \quad D_1, \dots, D_3.$$

Put $\mathcal{W} = \{W_1\}$ and $\mathcal{D} = \{D_1, \dots, D_3\}$. On the vertex set $\{A_i, B_i : i \in \mathbb{Z}/n\mathbb{Z}\} \cup \{C\} \cup \mathcal{D}$, define two three-uniform hypergraphs by

$$\begin{aligned} E(H_1) &= \bigcup_i \{ \{A_i, X, Y\} : X \in \{B_i, C\}, Y \in \{B_j : j \neq i\} \cup \mathcal{D} \}, \\ E(H_2) &= \bigcup_i \{ \{B_i, X, Y\} : X \in \{A_{i+1}, C\}, Y \in \{A_j : j \neq i+1\} \cup \mathcal{D} \}. \end{aligned}$$

All subscripts are read modulo n . Define

$$E(G_n) = \{\mathcal{W} \cup \{U\} \cup e : e \in E(H_1)\} \cup \{\mathcal{W} \cup \{V\} \cup e : e \in E(H_2)\} \cup \{\{U, V\} \cup \mathcal{D}\}. \quad (2.1)$$

Thus G_n is a simple 5-uniform hypergraph.

Use lower-case letters for the weights of the corresponding vertices, and write

$$A = \sum_i a_i, \quad B = \sum_i b_i, \quad D = \sum_{j=1}^3 d_j, \quad \omega = w_1.$$

The two cubic forms and the polynomial of G_n are

$$P_1 = \sum_i a_i(b_i + c)(B - b_i + D), \quad (2.2)$$

$$P_2 = \sum_i b_i(a_{i+1} + c)(A - a_{i+1} + D), \quad (2.3)$$

$$P_{G_n} = \omega(uP_1 + vP_2) + uv \prod_{j=1}^3 d_j. \quad (2.4)$$

Lemma 3. *The lower bound in (1.2) holds.*

Proof. Assign the weights

$$\begin{aligned} w_1 &= \frac{1}{5}, & u &= v = \frac{1}{10}, & a_i &= b_i = \frac{1}{5n}, \\ d_j &= \frac{1}{15n}, & c &= \frac{n-1}{5n}. \end{aligned} \quad (2.5)$$

Their sum is one. Moreover,

$$A = B = c + D = \frac{1}{5}, \quad b_i + c = B - b_i + D = a_{i+1} + c = A - a_{i+1} + D = \frac{1}{5}.$$

Thus $P_1 = P_2 = 5^{-3}$. The first term in (2.4) is 5^{-5} , and the second is

$$\frac{1}{100(15n)^3} = \frac{5^{-5}}{4(3n)^3}. \quad \square$$

3 A bound for open paths

The path estimate uses the following inequality for finite sequences.

Lemma 4. *Let $N \geq 1$, and let $x_0, \dots, x_N$ be nonnegative real numbers such that $x_N = 0$ and $\sum_{i=0}^{N-1} x_i \geq 1/2$. Then*

$$\sum_{i=0}^{N-1} x_i(1 - x_{i+1})^2 \geq \frac{2}{9}. \quad (3.1)$$

Proof. Define

$$\psi(x) = \begin{cases} x - x^2/2, & 0 \leq x \leq 1, \\ 1/2, & x > 1. \end{cases}$$

For all $x, y \geq 0$,

$$\psi(x) - \psi(y) \leq x(1 - y)^2. \quad (3.2)$$

For $x, y \leq 1$, this follows from the identity

$$x(1 - y)^2 - \psi(x) + \psi(y) = \frac{(x - 2y + y^2)^2 + y(1 - y)^2(2 - y)}{2} \geq 0.$$

If $y \geq 1$, the left side of (3.2) is nonpositive. If $x > 1 > y$, it equals $(1 - y)^2/2$, so the inequality holds in this case as well.

If some $x_j \geq 1/3$, summing (3.2) from j to $N - 1$ gives

$$\sum_{i=0}^{N-1} x_i(1 - x_{i+1})^2 \geq \psi(x_j) - \psi(0) \geq \frac{5}{18} > \frac{2}{9}.$$

Otherwise every $x_i < 1/3$, and the sum is at least $\frac{4}{9} \sum_{i=0}^{N-1} x_i \geq 2/9$. □

Lemma 5. Let $L \geq 1$, and let $a_1, \dots, a_L, b_1, \dots, b_L, c, D$ be nonnegative numbers. Put

$$A = \sum_{i=1}^L a_i, \quad B = \sum_{i=1}^L b_i, \quad a_{L+1} = 0,$$

and suppose that $A + B + c + D = 1$. Define P_1, P_2 by (2.2) and (2.3), with sums over $1 \leq i \leq L$. Then, for every $s \in [0, 1]$,

$$sP_1 + (1 - s)P_2 \leq \frac{1}{27} - \frac{s(1 - s)D^3}{10}. \quad (3.3)$$

Proof. Set

$$\delta_A = A - \frac{1}{3}, \quad \delta_B = B - \frac{1}{3}, \quad S = |\delta_A| + |\delta_B|,$$

and

$$\alpha = \frac{A + D - c}{2} = D + \delta_A + \frac{\delta_B}{2}, \quad \beta = \frac{B + D - c}{2} = D + \frac{\delta_A}{2} + \delta_B.$$

Completing the square gives

$$P_1 = \frac{A(1 - A)^2}{4} - \sum_i a_i(b_i - \beta)^2, \quad (3.4)$$

$$P_2 = \frac{B(1 - B)^2}{4} - \sum_i b_i(a_{i+1} - \alpha)^2. \quad (3.5)$$

Write

$$E = s \sum_i a_i(b_i - \beta)^2 + (1 - s) \sum_i b_i(a_{i+1} - \alpha)^2, \quad \Delta = \frac{1}{27} - sP_1 - (1 - s)P_2.$$

The exact identity

$$\Delta = \frac{s\delta_A^2(4/3 - A)}{4} + \frac{(1 - s)\delta_B^2(4/3 - B)}{4} + E$$

and the bounds $A, B \leq 1 - D$, $D \leq 1$ imply

$$\Delta \geq \frac{D}{3}(s\delta_A^2 + (1-s)\delta_B^2) + E.$$

Indeed, $(4/3 - A)/4 \geq (1/3 + D)/4 \geq D/3$, and similarly for B . By the weighted Cauchy–Schwarz inequality,

$$\Delta \geq \frac{s(1-s)DS^2}{3} + E. \quad (3.6)$$

If $S \geq 11D/20$, then

$$\Delta \geq \frac{121}{1200}s(1-s)D^3 \geq \frac{s(1-s)D^3}{10},$$

as required. Suppose therefore that $S < 11D/20$. Since $D \leq 1/3 + S$, we have

$$D \leq \frac{20}{27}, \quad A + B \geq \frac{2}{3} - S \geq \frac{7}{27} > \frac{1}{4}, \quad 0 < D - S \leq \alpha, \beta \leq \frac{1}{2}.$$

Apply Lemma 4 to the sequence

$$\frac{a_1}{\alpha}, \frac{b_1}{\beta}, \dots, \frac{a_L}{\alpha}, \frac{b_L}{\beta}, 0.$$

Its sum is $A/\alpha + B/\beta \geq 2(A+B) > 1/2$. Each successive pair x, y contributes to E a term $s\alpha\beta^2x(1-y)^2$ or $(1-s)\beta\alpha^2x(1-y)^2$. Consequently

$$E \geq \frac{2}{9} \min\{s\alpha\beta^2, (1-s)\beta\alpha^2\} \geq \frac{2}{9}s(1-s)(D-S)^3. \quad (3.7)$$

For completeness, for all $S, m \geq 0$ we have

$$\frac{(S+m)S^2}{3} + \frac{2m^3}{9} \geq \frac{(S+m)^3}{10}. \quad (3.8)$$

Multiplying the difference by 90 gives the nonnegative expression

$$\begin{aligned} & 21S^3 + 3S^2m - 27Sm^2 + 11m^3 \\ &= 21\left(S - \frac{3m}{5}\right)^2\left(S + \frac{6m}{5}\right) + 3m\left(S - \frac{18m}{25}\right)^2 + \frac{233m^3}{625}. \end{aligned}$$

Taking $m = D - S$ in (3.8) and using (3.6)–(3.7) proves (3.3). $\square$

For $L \geq 1$, define the 5-uniform hypergraph T_L as in (2.1), with each index ranging over $1, \dots, L$ and with the last link in H_2 replaced by the triples

$$\{B_L, C, Y\}, \quad Y \in \{A_1, \dots, A_L\} \cup \mathcal{D}.$$

The edge $\{U, V\} \cup \mathcal{D}$ is retained. Its polynomial is (2.4) with $a_{L+1} = 0$.

Lemma 6. *For every $L \geq 1$, we have $\lambda(T_L) = 5^{-5}$.*

Proof. The lower bound follows by assigning weight $1/5$ to the vertices of any one edge and zero elsewhere. For the upper bound, take nonnegative vertex weights of total mass one, and put

$$h = w_1, \quad q = u + v, \quad t = A + B + c + D.$$

Thus $h + q + t = 1$. If $q = 0$ or $t = 0$, then $P_{T_L} = 0$. Otherwise put

$$s = u/q, \quad d = D/t, \quad z = s(1-s)d^3 \in [0, 1/4].$$

Applying Lemma 5 to the bottom weights divided by t , and then using homogeneity, gives

$$uP_1 + vP_2 \leq qt^3 \left(\frac{1}{27} - \frac{z}{10} \right).$$

The arithmetic–geometric mean inequality now yields

$$P_{T_L} \leq hqt^3 \left(\frac{1}{27} - \frac{z}{10} \right) + q^2s(1-s) \left(\frac{td}{3} \right)^3. \quad (3.9)$$

Also,

$$\frac{qt^3}{27} \leq \left(\frac{q+t}{4} \right)^4, \quad \frac{q^2t^3}{3^3} \leq 4 \left(\frac{q+t}{5} \right)^5. \quad (3.10)$$

Define

$$F(h) = \frac{3125}{256} h(1-h)^4.$$

We have $F(h) \leq 1$, with equality at $h = 1/5$. Since $1 - 27z/10 > 0$, we may substitute (3.10) into (3.9). We get

$$\begin{aligned} \frac{P_{T_L}}{5^{-5}} &\leq F(h) \left(1 - \frac{27}{10}z \right) + 4s(1-s)d^3(1-h)^5 \\ &= F(h) + z \left[4(1-h)^5 - \frac{27}{10}F(h) \right]. \end{aligned} \quad (3.11)$$

It remains to show that

$$\left(1 - \frac{27}{40} \right) F(h) + (1-h)^5 \leq 1 \quad (0 \leq h \leq 1). \quad (3.12)$$

Indeed, the last expression in (3.11) is the convex combination

$$(1-4z)F(h) + 4z \left[\left(1 - \frac{27}{40} \right) F(h) + (1-h)^5 \right].$$

Since $(1 - 27/40)(3125/256) = 8125/2048 < 5$, the binomial expansion gives

$$\left(1 - \frac{27}{40} \right) F(h) + (1-h)^5 \leq 5h(1-h)^4 + (1-h)^5 \leq (h + (1-h))^5 = 1.$$

This completes the upper bound. □

4 The Lagrangian bound and the blow-ups

Proof of Proposition 2. The lower bound was proved in Lemma 3. For the upper bound, take any nonnegative weights on G_n of total mass one. Choose an index k with

$$a_k + b_k \leq \frac{A+B}{n} \leq \frac{1}{n}.$$

Put $a'_j = a_{k+j}$, $b'_j = b_{k+j}$ for $1 \leq j \leq n-1$, with indices modulo n , and set $A' = \sum_j a'_j$, $B' = \sum_j b'_j$, $a'_n = 0$. After deleting A_k, B_k , the remaining polynomial is

$$\begin{aligned} P_{G_n - \{A_k, B_k\}} &= \omega u \sum_{j=1}^{n-1} a'_j (b'_j + c) (B' - b'_j + D) \\ &\quad + \omega v \sum_{j=1}^{n-1} b'_j (a'_{j+1} + c) (A' - a'_{j+1} + D) + uv \prod_{\ell=1}^3 d_\ell \\ &= P_{T_{n-1}}. \end{aligned} \tag{4.1}$$

Thus Lemma 6 and homogeneity bound the total weight of the edges that remain by

$$5^{-5} (1 - a_k - b_k)^5 \leq 5^{-5}.$$

For any simple 5-uniform hypergraph and weights of total mass one,

$$\frac{\partial P_H}{\partial x_v} \leq \sum_{\substack{S \subseteq V(H) \setminus \{v\} \\ |S|=4}} \prod_{w \in S} x_w \leq \frac{(\sum_{w \neq v} x_w)^4}{4!} \leq \frac{1}{4!}. \tag{4.2}$$

Indeed, each product of four distinct weights occurs $4!$ times in the power expansion, and all other terms are nonnegative. The deleted edges consequently have total weight at most

$$a_k \frac{\partial P_{G_n}}{\partial a_k} + b_k \frac{\partial P_{G_n}}{\partial b_k} \leq \frac{a_k + b_k}{4!} \leq \frac{1}{4!n}.$$

This proves (1.2). □

Proof of Theorem 1. Fix $\gamma > 5^{-5}$, and choose an integer $n \geq 2$ such that

$$5^{-5} + \frac{1}{4!n} < \gamma.$$

Keep n fixed, and set

$$\varepsilon = \frac{1}{4(3n)^3} > 0.$$

For each positive integer M , form a blow-up $B_{n,M}$ of G_n : replace each vertex by an independent class, and each edge by all transversal edges across its five classes. Use the following class sizes, with one class for each listed vertex:

vertex	W_j	U, V	A_i, B_i	C	D_j
class size	$6nM$	$3nM$	$6M$	$6(n-1)M$	$2M$

There are $N = 30nM$ vertices. These class sizes are proportional to the weights in (2.5), and the computation in Lemma 3 gives the exact edge count

$$e(B_{n,M}) = [(6n)^5 + 72n^2]M^5 = (1 + \varepsilon)(N/5)^5. \tag{4.3}$$

Let S be any nonempty set of m vertices of $B_{n,M}$, and let k_v be the number of its vertices in the class corresponding to $v \in V(G_n)$. Then

$$e(B_{n,M}[S]) = \sum_{e \in E(G_n)} \prod_{v \in e} k_v = m^5 P_{G_n}((k_v/m)_v) \leq m^5 \lambda(G_n) < \gamma m^5.$$

Together with (4.3) and $M \rightarrow \infty$, this proves the theorem. A non-induced subgraph has no more edges than the induced subgraph on the same vertex set. □

Corollary 7. *For every integer $r \geq 5$ and every $\gamma > r^{-r}$, there is an $\varepsilon > 0$ and there are arbitrarily large r -uniform hypergraphs H such that*

$$e(H) \geq (1 + \varepsilon)(v(H)/r)^r, \quad e(H[S]) < \gamma|S|^r \quad \text{for every nonempty } S \subseteq V(H).$$

In particular, Problem 1075 fails for every $r \geq 5$.

Proof. This is the lifting step of Peng [6]; in the present normalization it has the following direct form. Let $q = r - 5$. For a 5-uniform hypergraph G , form an r -uniform hypergraph G^{+q} by adjoining the same set of q new vertices to every edge. If the total weight on $V(G)$ is t , then the arithmetic–geometric mean inequality gives

$$P_{G^{+q}} \leq \lambda(G)t^5 \left(\frac{1-t}{q} \right)^q,$$

with the usual interpretation when $q = 0$. The right side is maximized at $t = 5/r$, and equality is attained by taking an optimal weighting of G , scaled by $5/r$, and weight $1/r$ on each new vertex. Hence

$$\lambda(G^{+q}) = \frac{5^5}{r^r} \lambda(G). \tag{4.4}$$

Applying (4.4) to G_n and using Proposition 2 gives

$$r^{-r} \left(1 + \frac{1}{4(3n)^3} \right) \leq \lambda(G_n^{+q}) \leq r^{-r} + \frac{5^5}{r^r 4! n}.$$

Choose n so that the upper bound is less than γ . The blow-up argument in the proof of Theorem 1, using the rational weighting obtained by suspending (2.5), then gives the stated r -uniform hypergraphs with $\varepsilon = 1/[4(3n)^3]$. $\square$

Declaration of generative AI and AI-assisted technologies

OpenAI Codex (GPT-6 Astra) was used to generate the mathematical proofs, draft the manuscript, and write the Lean formalization. GPT-5.6 Sol and Claude Opus 5 were used only for editorial review of the exposition. The author reviewed the final manuscript and takes full responsibility for its content.

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